

# Subtraction and Negative Signs: Diagnosing the Error

## Grade 6–7 The Number System

---

**Before you compute, rewrite every subtraction as an addition:**

- $p - q$  means  $p + (-q)$  — “add the opposite” of the second number.
- Subtracting a negative adds a positive:  $p - (-q) = p + q$ , so the result moves *right* on the number line.
- Subtracting a positive adds a negative, so the result moves *left*.
- The sign of the answer follows the number with the larger distance from zero, not the one written first.

For every find-and-fix item: name the step where the sign was lost, then redo it correctly.

---

- 1.** Rewrite as an addition, then evaluate.

$$-8 - (-3)$$

Answer: \_\_\_\_\_

- 2.** Rewrite as an addition, then evaluate. Say in one phrase why the answer is negative even though the first number is positive.

$$5 - 12$$

Answer: \_\_\_\_\_

3. Evaluate. Keep the decimals exact — do not round.

$$-3.5 - 2.25$$

Answer: \_\_\_\_\_

4. Write the correct symbol ( $<$ ,  $>$ , or  $=$ ) in the blank, then finish the sentence below it.

$$-8 - (-3) \quad \underline{\hspace{1cm}} \quad -8 + 3$$

Subtracting  $-3$  has the same effect as \_\_\_\_\_ because  
\_\_\_\_\_.

Answer: \_\_\_\_\_

5. Order these three values from **least to greatest**. Write the three results, not the expressions.

$$-2 - 7 \quad 2 - 7 \quad -2 + 7$$

Answer: \_\_\_\_\_

**6. Find and fix the mistake.** Dana turns in this work:

$$-4 - (-9) = -13$$

Dana's answer is  $-13$ . Name the rule she broke, then write the correct value.

Answer: \_\_\_\_\_

**7. Find and fix the mistake.** Marcus turns in this work:

$$-7 - 4 = -3$$

Marcus's answer is  $-3$ . Name the rule he broke, then write the correct value.

Answer: \_\_\_\_\_

**8. Challenge — find and fix.** A student evaluates a three-term expression left to right and gets  $-12.75$ :

$$-2.5 - (-6) - 4.25$$

Identify the single sign the student mishandled, rewrite all of the subtractions as additions, and compute the correct value.

Answer: \_\_\_\_\_